

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 43

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A young football referee describes officiating his first major match — the regional youth final.

1

The tunnel smelled of liniment and damp concrete, and I could hear, somewhere ahead of me, the muffled thunder of a crowd that was no longer thinking about me at all. I checked my whistle three times, which is twice more than necessary, and pretended that my hands were steady. I was nineteen years old, two years out of the youth training scheme, and the man who had been due to take this final had broken his ankle on a Sunday-league pitch the previous weekend. The appointments officer had rung me on the Tuesday. He had used the word “ready” twice, as though saying it might make it so.

2

We walked out into the noise. The two captains, both shorter than me and both, I suspected, less nervous, shook hands while the photographers crouched. I tossed the coin without dropping it, which I counted as a private victory. The grass had been cut that morning to a precise eighteen millimetres; I knew this because I had asked, three times, like a man checking the locks before bed. The whistle, when I finally blew it, sounded distant, as though somebody else had blown it for me, and the ball was already moving before I had quite registered that the match had begun.

3

For seven minutes everything was easy. The play stayed in the middle third; I gave a throw-in correctly, then a goal kick, and the crowd noise settled into the background hum it is supposed to be. Then a winger in red went down inside the area. He had not been touched cleanly — a trailing leg, perhaps, brushing the back of his ankle — and he had gone down very theatrically. But there had been contact, of a sort, and the rulebook is unsentimental about contact in the box. I pointed at the spot before I had quite finished thinking, because hesitation, I had been taught, is worse than being wrong.

4

The boos came at me from three sides at once. The blue captain was suddenly very close, his face the

colour of his shirt, asking how I could possibly, how I could **possibly**, and behind him a coach was shouting something I was glad I could not quite hear. I did not raise my voice. I had been told, in the long sober briefings of the training scheme, that a referee who shouts has already lost. I held up a hand, pointed again at the spot, and walked away with what I hoped was the brisk neutrality of a man who has made up his mind. The penalty was scored. One-nil. The boos did not stop for a long time.

5

At half-time I sat alone in a windowless room that smelled, faintly, of paint. My two assistants had gone to fetch water. I unscrewed the cap of my own bottle and discovered that I could not, just for a moment, remember whether the penalty had been right. I went through it in my head — the angle, the trailing leg, the small puff of dust as the boy had gone down — and could not make myself certain. This, nobody had warned me about. The loneliness of it. The fact that there was nobody, in that small painted room, whose job it was to tell me I had not been a fool.

6

The second half was tighter. The blue team equalised, then went ahead, and the crowd, which had been against me, became, in the way crowds do, against nobody in particular. With four minutes left, a defender in red lunged in late on the blue striker just outside the area. It was a yellow card, comfortably — perhaps, on a strict reading, a red. The striker stayed down. The red bench was already on its feet, anticipating my decision and disagreeing with it in advance.

7

I walked towards the incident at a deliberate, unhurried pace. I had learned that, too: that the speed of the referee's walk tells the players what kind of decision is coming. I asked the striker, quietly, if he could continue. I asked my nearest assistant, by radio, what he had seen. I waited for the trainer to finish his work. Only then did I reach into my pocket. Yellow. I held it up clearly, at arm's length, so that the bench, the crowd, and the television camera behind the goal could all see it together. The red captain nodded once, briefly, and turned away. It was, I realised later, the first decision of the afternoon that nobody on either side had bothered to argue with.

8

The final whistle, when I blew it, sounded like my own again. I shook the captains' hands. I shook the coaches' hands, including the one who had been shouting in the first half, who now would not quite meet my eye. In the tunnel afterwards, the appointments officer clapped me, just once, on the shoulder, and said only, "Good." I have refereed many bigger matches since. I have been booed more loudly, and praised more warmly. But I have never again felt quite as alone as I did in that small painted room at half-time, holding a bottle of water, trying to remember whether I had been right.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says the appointments officer "had used the word 'ready' twice, as though saying it might make it so." Explain, in your own words, what this suggests about whether the narrator was truly prepared for the match. [2]

2. Give **one** detail from Paragraph 1 that shows the narrator was nervous before the match. [1]

From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator describes himself as "a man checking the locks before bed." Explain what this comparison suggests about his behaviour before the match. [2]

4. The narrator says the whistle "sounded distant, as though somebody else had blown it for me." What does this tell us about his state of mind at the kick-off? [2]

From Paragraph 3

5. The narrator says, “hesitation, I had been taught, is worse than being wrong.” Explain, in your own words, why he gives the penalty so quickly. [2]

From Paragraph 4

6. The narrator describes his response to the protests using words such as “brisk neutrality” and “I did not raise my voice.” Explain how the language in this paragraph shows that the narrator was trying to assert his **authority**. Support your answer with **two** details from Paragraph 4. [3]

From Paragraph 5

7. The narrator says, “This, nobody had warned me about. The loneliness of it.” What does the **sentence structure** of these short sentences suggest about the narrator’s feelings at half-time? [2]

8. Why does the narrator find it so disturbing that there was “nobody... whose job it was to tell me I had not been a fool”? [1]

From Paragraph 6

9. The narrator says the crowd “became, in the way crowds do, against nobody in particular.” What does this comment suggest about the writer’s view of crowds? [1]

From Paragraph 7

10. In Paragraph 7, the narrator handles the late tackle in a notably calm and methodical way. Give **two** actions he takes before he reaches for a card, and explain what each shows about his approach. [2]

From Paragraph 8

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article weighing the case for and against banning smartphones in schools.

1

A decade ago, it was unusual to see a smartphone in a Year 7 classroom. Today, it is unusual not to. The device that began as a parental safety measure — a way of ensuring that a child could be reached on the bus home — has become, in the words of one head teacher, “a small casino in every blazer pocket.” Schools are increasingly being asked, by parents, by ministers and by their own staff, whether the answer is simply to ban the things outright. The question is more complicated than it first appears.

2

The case for a ban is, on the evidence, a strong one. A 2023 review by the London School of Economics concluded that pupils in schools with a strict phone ban scored, on average, a third of a grade higher in standardised tests, with the largest gains among lower-attaining students. Sleep researchers have long been clear that the late-night use of smartphones, particularly for social media, delays the onset of sleep by an average of forty-three minutes; chronic under-sleeping is itself a leading driver of poor concentration in the classroom. And the rise in online bullying — which, unlike playground bullying, follows a child home through the device in their pocket — has been documented in study after study.

3

There is also the experience of countries that have already moved. France banned smartphones in primary and lower-secondary schools in 2018; teachers there report calmer corridors, more conversation at lunch, and a measurable fall in the number of behavioural incidents recorded. Several large academy chains in England have followed suit since 2022, often using lockable pouches rather than outright confiscation. Early evidence from these schools is broadly positive, though, as critics rightly note, schools that volunteer for such a policy may simply be schools where discipline was good to begin with.

4

The case against a ban is rarely heard as loudly, but it is not negligible. The strongest argument is one of digital literacy. A child who never encounters a phone at school will not, on that account, encounter fewer phones in life; they will simply encounter them later, with less supervision and less guidance. Several teachers have argued, with some force, that the classroom is precisely the place where young people should learn to use a device thoughtfully — to fact-check, to disengage, to recognise when an algorithm is manipulating them. A school that bans the phone outright, they suggest, gives up that teaching opportunity in exchange for a quieter corridor.

5

There is, too, the question of equity. A blanket ban affects different children differently. A pupil with diabetes whose insulin pump is monitored through her phone, a pupil with hearing loss who relies on a live-captioning app, and a young carer who must be contactable about a sick parent — all of these stand to lose more from a ban than the average pupil, and to gain less. Any sensible policy must therefore be honest about its exceptions, and must take care that those exceptions do not, in practice, single out the children who need them most.

6

What, then, might a realistic policy look like? Most education researchers now converge on a “moderate” model rather than a “total” one. Phones are not allowed in lessons or at break times, but pupils may carry them, switched off, in their bags; pouches or lockers are used in the most distractible age groups; medical and accessibility exceptions are written into the school’s policy in plain English rather than buried in an appendix. Crucially, the policy is accompanied — not replaced — by structured lessons in digital literacy, in which pupils examine, in class, how their attention is captured and sold.

7

The smartphone is not going away, and pretending that schools can wish it out of existence is unlikely to help anyone. But neither is it a neutral object, indifferent to whether a child is in geometry or in Geography. Treating it as the casino some now believe it to be — designed, by people far cleverer than the average twelve-year-old, to capture attention and sell it on — is no longer a fringe view. The real choice before schools is not whether to take the device seriously, but how.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer quotes a head teacher who calls the smartphone “a small casino in every blazer pocket.” Explain, in your own words, what this comparison suggests about the smartphone. [2]

From Paragraph 2

13. According to Paragraph 2, give **two** pieces of evidence that suggest smartphones harm pupils. [2]

14. The writer says online bullying “follows a child home through the device in their pocket.” Explain what this tells us about how online bullying differs from older forms of bullying. [2]

From Paragraph 3

15. The writer notes that “schools that volunteer for such a policy may simply be schools where discipline was good to begin with.” What does this admission tell us about the reliability of the evidence from these schools? [2]

From Paragraph 4

16. Explain, in your own words, the argument from **digital literacy** that the writer outlines in Paragraph 4. [2]

From Paragraph 5

17. The writer says that any sensible policy “must take care that those exceptions do not, in practice, single out the children who need them most.” Explain what concern the writer is raising here. [2]

From Paragraph 6

18. Give **two** features of the “moderate” model described in Paragraph 6. [2]

19. The writer says that digital literacy lessons should **accompany**, not **replace**, the phone policy. Explain why the writer makes this distinction. [2]

From Paragraph 7

20. The writer ends, “The real choice before schools is not whether to take the device seriously, but how.” Explain what is **effective** about ending the article with this sentence. [2]

21. What is the writer’s overall **tone** in this article? [1]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **the arguments for banning smartphones in schools**, and **the arguments against doing so**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 2 to 5** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Supporters of a ban argue that smartphones ...

— END OF PAPER —